ONE-OFF SHIURIM

What Should I Do When Bad Things Happen?

Derech Hashem 2:3:11-12

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 3, paragraphs 11-12, and the opening of Chapter 4 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 14 June 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

A story for Parashat Korah

Having finished the long discussion of gilgulim, the Rabbi told a story fitting the week's parashah. A nineteenth-century Hasidic Rebbe in Poland claimed to be a gilgul of someone who lived in the time of Korah and Moshe. His hasidim asked which side he had been on. He said he had been neutral. When they were shocked, he explained that Korah's arguments were so persuasive that he had found it hard even to stay neutral. Whether or not the story is true, the Rabbi said, the point is real: Korah's arguments were strong. They sound very democratic, while Moshe seems to be the autocrat. "That's a discussion for another time."

Paragraph 11: the reasons do not all work at once

Over the past weeks the Ramhal has given six reasons why the righteous may suffer and the wicked prosper. Now he ties them together. "Nimsa lefi kol zeh she-beiarnu..." There are many different roots for what happens to people, for good or bad. But not everything in a person's life is the product of all of them together. Some things happen because of one reason and some because of another. The Divine wisdom oversees everything with precision, takes every detail into account, and leads the world accordingly. The reasons will not always produce the same result; often one contradicts another.

The Ramhal's example: by the principle of following one's parents, a person should be wealthy, because his parents were. By his own actions he deserves poverty. And by the principle of roles, he may have been assigned poverty too. One reason says wealth, another poverty.

Even a person's own actions pull in different directions. One deed may bring a good result and another deed take it away.

Don't cherry-pick the sayings of Hazal

From this the Rabbi drew a practical lesson he feels strongly about. The Gemara says that one who is careful with netilat yadayim, or with respect for bread, becomes wealthy; that one who gives maaser becomes rich. Someone hears this in a shiur, goes home, tells the whole family

that from now on they will be meticulous, and then waits, and nothing changes. "I know hundreds of people who give maaser and don't become rich."

The answer is that the statement is true: from that particular deed, that is a segulah for wealth. But there are other things he did, or failed to do, that take it away. "You can't take statements of Hakhamim out of context. You have to look at the whole picture." A participant added that we do not even know the relative weight of each misvah, as the Mishnah teaches. The Rabbi agreed. When teaching such sayings, one should say: this is one factor among many.

You cannot answer "why Mr X?"

This is why the Ramhal ends by saying it is enough to know the principles. Why one person gets gilgul and another Gehinnom, no one can say. The Rabbi reminded the group that he said at the start of this chapter not to ask him why something happened to a particular person. "If you want to ask me why Mr X, who's so bad, something good happened, or Mr Y, who's so good, something bad happened, no one can answer that." Anyone who claims to is pretending to know what he cannot know. "How can a human being comprehend these different details?"

Paragraph 12: ends and means

The last point of the chapter divides everything that happens to us into two kinds: - **Ends in themselves (takhlitiyim):** things that happen as a final consequence of one of the reasons explained. Illness or loss that cleanses sins, or the suffering of the saddik and hasid for their generation. The suffering is itself the purpose. - **Means to an end (emsaiyim):** things that are not the purpose themselves, but lead to something else. Hashem wants a person to reach something, but by a roundabout way, through something unpleasant.

The examples: a person's cow falls and breaks a leg, and underneath he finds a treasure. Or someone is delayed and misses his ship, and the ship sinks at sea. As Hazal read the verse "Odekha Hashem ki anafta bi," I thank You, Hashem, that You were angry with me. Today we might say: you missed your flight, and the plane crashed.

The Rabbi stressed that it is rarely so dramatic. Perhaps in that extra hour of waiting you received a phone call, or needed to realise something. A participant pointed out that the annoyance of missing a flight could itself be cleansing. The Rabbi agreed: "Could be. But it can also be a means to something else."

"Now that it has happened, what should I do?"

This is why the Gemara in Berakhot says that when a person sees suffering coming upon him, he should examine his deeds. First ask whether this is a means to an end, a message. "What's God trying to tell me with missing this flight?" If you look honestly and find nothing, then accept that it may be cleansing for something past.

The first attitude should never be "Why me?" which is passive, but "Now that it's happened, what should I do?" which is active. A participant noted that jumping straight to "it's an atonement for sins" can be the lazy answer, and the Rabbi agreed. He added a balance: you

must not drive yourself mad over every stumble. But when big things happen in life, stop and think.

A participant asked about "everything is for the good." The Rabbi answered: yes, everything is for the good, but what are you going to do with it? He cited Rabbi Sacks, who described two kinds of Holocaust survivors. Some, whom we can never judge, lived the rest of their lives in anguish asking why. Others asked what they could now do to change the world, and those inspired him most, "because instead of being victims, they became active contributors." Similarly, someone who has suffered abuse may decide to found an organisation to fight it and raise awareness. To say "it's all for the good" and do nothing is "a cop-out." "How are you going to make it good? You make it good."

The means may even serve someone else: what happened to you may bring awareness that changes other people's lives.

Closing the chapter, opening the next

The Rabbi called chapters 2 and 3 together probably the most important in terms of our relationship with Hashem, and advised reviewing the reasons. But: "Do not start using the different explanations on different people as guinea pigs."

He then introduced Chapter 4, on Israel and the nations, with the questions it raises. Is there an intrinsic difference between a Jew and a non-Jew, beyond the obvious difference in misvot? Is the soul different? What is the place of converts? And who was the first Jew: Adam, Noah, Avraham, Moshe, or only after Sinai? If Avraham, in what sense, when the Torah was given centuries later?

Summary

- Paragraph 11: the different reasons for suffering and prosperity often contradict each other, and Hashem weighs them all with precision.
- So a single saying of Hazal (bread, netilat yadayim, maaser) is one factor among many, not a guarantee.
- No one can explain why a particular person suffers; we know only the principles.
- Paragraph 12: some events are ends in themselves, others are means leading somewhere else.
- The right response to hardship is not "why me?" but "what should I do now?"

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